



ORDERLY ALLIANCE: NDA Lok Sabha members

himself had disrupted the House when he was an MP. Two instances came immediately to mind. His frequent interruptions of then finance minister Manmohan Singh's budget speech in the 1990s and during a debate on Bofors in 1989. Samajwadi Party's Mohan Singh said that the Speaker was not a monarch and the MPs his subjects. When the BJP stated that it was embarking on a non-cooperation movement, External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee prevailed on the Speaker to reconsider his decision by working out a compromise with the Leader of the Opposition L.K. Advani.

For now a crisis has been averted. Jubilant BJP MP Shahnawaz Hussain said, "The Speaker is a good man but he gets angry easily. In the end, our silence proved more eloquent." **by Priya Sahgal**

The Eloquence of Silence

DELHI Gandhigiri has finally reached the Indian Parliament. On the morning of May 5, all the NDA MPs trooped silently into the lower House and sat in the Opposition benches with a finger on their lips. They were protesting against Speaker Somnath

Chatterjee's decision to refer 32 MPs to the Privileges Committee for "disorderly conduct". Barring one BSP MP, all the others were from the NDA.

The confrontation, which had been brewing for some time with the Speaker voicing his anger

at the frequent disruptions, came to a head on April 24 when NDA MPs stormed into the well of the House shouting anti-inflation slogans while BSP MP Brajesh Pathak asked Ram Vilas Paswan a question but did not allow him to reply. An angry Chatterjee called the Zero Hour the "torture hour".

An upset Opposition recalled how Chatterjee

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Who says politicians have no sartorial sense? At the recent opening of the Brioni store in Delhi, the first customers for the Italian brand's iconic and expensive suits were Union ministers—one from the Congress, the other from the NCP.

VOICES



"I have no faith in the Congress. If Rahul Gandhi and his coterie are not happy with you, you cannot be in the party."

Akhilesh Das, former Union minister and Congress MP

"The policies of the US are responsible for foodgrain shortage. Those who criticise should not set apart farmland for other purposes. The US should rectify its mistakes."

A.K. Antony, defence minister

"Abu Asim Azmi (Mumbai SP leader) had said he would bring 20,000 people from Azamgarh in Uttar Pradesh. If he does so, 40,000 legs will be returned from here."

Raj Thackeray, Maharashtra Navnirman Sena chief

"IPL is for entertainment. The JD(s)-BJP during their 20-month rule (in Karnataka) have already provided entertainment to people. People now want stable governance."

Kapil Sibal, Congress leader

"It is absolutely marvellous to be with children. They come without any baggage. They are efficient and full of surprises. Kids and animals can upstage you and destroy your job."

Amitabh Bachchan, actor

